conduct, a common code of business ethics'. He wanted the public to be aware that Tata companies do not undertake 'practices that some of the business groups do' but grow in an 'ethical manner'.

The TCoC had a telling impact on the way Tata companies did business, not just in India but around the world. Speaking about how it empowered Tata companies, Mike Odera, former CEO of Tata Magadi, a soda ash unit under Tata Chemicals in Kenya, says that it 'made a great impact'. Business ethics became 'critical'. Company officials could now deny favours to 'local politicians' and suppliers who tried to 'muscle in'. They could declare that they had the 'support of the group chairman' to do business in an ethical manner. The code helped both the company and its stakeholders.

The Tata Brand Equity and Business Promotion Agreement

One of the problems that Ratan pivoted his attention on after becoming chairman was the issue of the Tata brand. Virtually all its promoted companies had different logos. He saw this as a serious drawback, and opined that it would be 'difficult, if not impossible, to retain their product visibility against the substantial promotional efforts' of 'global companies', which would soon make their presence felt in a liberalized India.

Ratan's vision was to create a symbol that would be an assurance of the quality that the name Tata had come to represent. He said that each company should 'be part of a large group and be recognized as one large Group'.

Sandipan Chakravortty, a long-serving mentor of TBEM and MD, Tata Steel Processing and Distribution Ltd, recalls the occasion where Ratan drove home the need for a common emblem for Tata companies. 'In one of the several meetings Ratan held with the CEOs and the senior functionaries, he surprised everybody by posing a question. He asked: "Do you know how many Tata companies there are?" Nobody said anything. He then turned to Ishaat Hussain and asked, "Can you guess?" Taken aback, he responded with a question: "With subsidiaries or without it?" Ratan chose not to answer that and said, "More than a hundred, we do not even know."'

He then requested R. Gopalakrishnan, who had joined Tata Sons as executive director after serving as vice chairman of Hindustan Lever, to display the slides of the various group companies. Each had a different logo. Ratan queried: 'Where is the Tata-ness in this? All brands are good.